

especially in the manufacturing sector, are working with women. Experts note that this is driven by sectors such as automotive and electronics. “Women are opening up to jobs quite a bit. We have seen a 5x increase in the number of women being inducted into manufacturing, which has traditionally been a male-led workforce,” says TeamLease’s Reddy.

### REMOTE WORK

Though some companies insist on workers gradually returning to offices, hybrid and WFH have become irrevocable conditions of the modern workplace.

What’s more, several larger firms are looking to hire local, non-metro talent with the requisite skills. They are even willing to pay the same amount as they pay employees in metros if the candidate meets their criteria.

Giri of Randstad notes that most companies (apart from the IT sector) are looking at a hybrid model of work where employees work for two to three days from the office. “However, in several sectors, WFH is not possible—such as manufacturing, engineering, logistics, and retail. Most women tend to prefer a hybrid mode of working as they are the primary carers at home,” he says.

Randstad India has started a four-day work week option for employees who meet their targets ahead of schedule. They can enjoy a Friday-Sunday weekend for the rest of the calendar year. A good number of people availed of this last year, the firm says.

### OTHER BENEFITS

And that’s not all. There are a host of other benefits that companies are offering now to keep their top workers engaged.

For instance, post-pandemic,



**“THE KEY ASKS OF EMPLOYEES NOW ARE WORK-LIFE BALANCE, PAY, JOB SECURITY, CAREER OPPORTUNITIES AND MENTAL SUPPORT, WORKING HOUR FLEXIBILITY, AND SKILLING AND DEVELOPMENT”**

**YESHAB GIRI**

CCO, Operational Talent Solutions, Randstad India



**“EVEN SENIOR EMPLOYEES NEED TO BE SKILLED TO REMAIN RELEVANT. A LOT OF COMPANIES ARE NOW INVESTING IN SKILL DEVELOPMENT”**

**RAMESH ALLURI REDDY**

CEO, TeamLease Degree Apprenticeship

mental well-being has emerged as a key focus area. “Therapy is no longer seen as a bad word. With the fast pace of modern life and living alone in big cities, many employees often do not have a fallback option. In such cases, employers are now stepping in,” says a recruiter who did not wish to be named.

Dutta of ISF notes that during the pandemic, staffing companies stepped in to help the families of workers who passed away. “Staffing companies stepped in to figure out who was the next best person in the family to be skilled and brought into the labour force. These are very subtle things that are being done and are also motivating people to come into the formal workforce,” she highlights.

There are other ways in which staffing firms are looking out for their employees. Such workers often find it challenging to access loans as they move from job to job. Most staffing companies are trying to ensure that financial services are accessible to these workers. “This category needs financial independence and social security protection as well. While EPFO and ESIC coverage are mandatory, some companies also provide them with medical insurance, personal accident insurance, and death insurance,” Dutta says.

Many others are taking a fresh look at office infrastructure as well. This means providing adequate parking facilities, breakout rooms to de-stress, and nutritious meals.

The Beatles had sung the lines ‘Money can’t buy me love’ as part of their hit song, ‘Can’t Buy Me Love’ from the album *A Hard Day’s Night* (1964). Companies are waking up to it 60 years later. **BT**

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